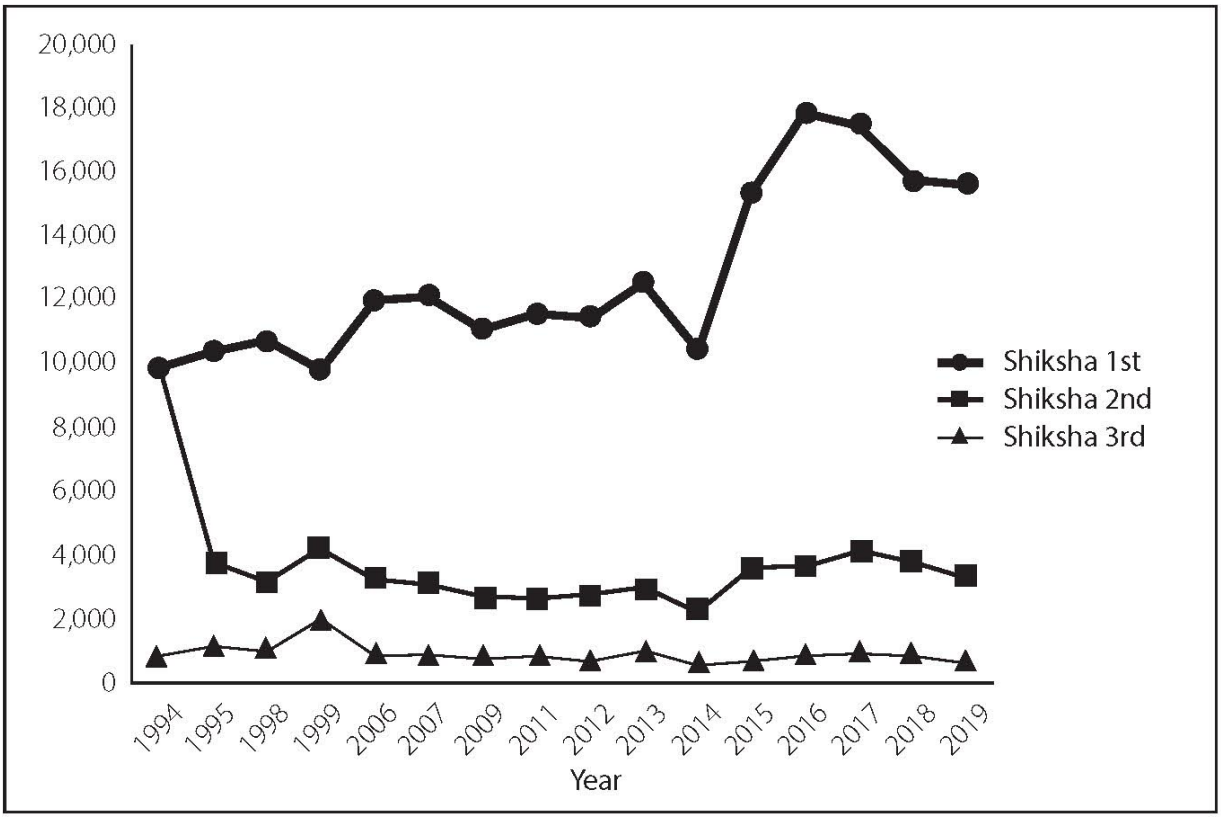


Source: RSS Annual Reports

How the RSS Grew: A Case Study of Karnataka

It is equally important to understand what has driven the expansion of the RSS in recent years. Sangh leaders say that online outreach has been the biggest source of expansion since the early 2010s. In 2018, it launched a 'Join RSS' initiative on its website, which a senior Sangh functionary claimed was yielding about 10,000 new recruits per month on average.[23]

The RSS's growth strategy in Karnataka is an instructive case study. In February 2020, I travelled to Bengaluru to meet with a group of state Sangh leaders and understand how they viewed these changes. At the state headquarters in Chamarajpet in Old Bengaluru, Radhakrishna Holla, RSS communications head for Karnataka, told me that that over the last 'six–seven years' they had focused on their website. 'Anybody can register with an email and a number,' he said. 'The result is that in Bengaluru City we get about 200-400 memberships each month as registrations from website